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‘In the middle of winter, it gives you something to talk about.’

LARRY ROSSI, *describing part of the appeal of the ice-out contest on Joe’s Pond*

That sinking feeling winter is over

In a northern Vt. village, a complicated contraption signals the change of seasons

By Paul Heintz
GLOBE STAFF

WEST DANVILLE, Vt. — Nobody heard it and nobody saw it, but with an icy swoosh, spring finally reached northern Vermont at 6:21 a.m. on Thursday.

The moment was marked when a 50-pound contraption consisting of a pair of concrete blocks affixed to a wood pallet plunged through the last remaining ice on Joe’s Pond in this hibernating corner of the Northeast Kingdom. When the ballast fell, it yanked a rope tied to a pair of wires 100 yards away on a lakeside porch. The sudden tug cut the power to an ana-

log clock leaning against a nearby home, capturing the time with absurd precision.

The ice was officially out on Joe’s Pond. The scene has been similar each spring since 1988, when village elders in this vacation hamlet established the Joe’s Pond Ice-Out Contest, perhaps Vermont’s quirkiest seasonal tradition. For a dollar a pop, locals and visitors alike can guess the exact moment the Rube Goldberg device will be triggered. The person who comes closest to predicting the official ice-out time takes half the pot — amounting to about \$16,000 this year — and the rest goes to water-quality improvements on the pond.

“In the middle of winter, it gives you something to talk about,” said Larry Rossi, 75, a building contractor who assembles the contraption each winter, places it on the ice and later retrieves it from its watery rest.

Once a thriving granite and lumber community, Joe’s Pond has been a summer destination for more than a century, with some 300 dwellings now clustered around the 400-acre body of water. It straddles the town line between West Danville and Cabot, about two-thirds of the way from Montpelier to St. Johnsbury. Because the pond is situated at a relatively high eleva-

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READY FOR THE FINISH



LANE TURNER/GLOBE STAFF

A portrait of Ottavio “Peppi” Bolognese (right) watched over the installation of the Boston Marathon finish line graphic Thursday on Boylston Street. The Accurate Graphics company of Lynn has installed the finish line for 27 years. This was the first without Bolognese, who died in October. His family brought his portrait for “his favorite day of the year.” **B1.**

Iran declares strait is open, but Trump less definitive

US suggests a new round of talks could be near

By Kareem Chehayeb, Aamer Madhani, and Elena Becatoros
ASSOCIATED PRESS

BEIRUT — Iran said Friday it fully reopened the Strait of Hormuz to commercial vessels, but US President Trump said the American blockade on Iranian ships and ports “will remain in full force” until Tehran reaches a deal with the US, including on its nuclear program.

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi posted on X that the crucial waterway, through which about 20 percent of the world’s oil is shipped, was now fully open to commercial vessels, as a 10-day truce between Israel and the Iranian-backed Hezbollah militant group in Lebanon appeared to hold.

Araghchi said ships will use routes designated by the Islamic Republic in coordination with Iranian authorities, suggesting Iran planned to retain some level of control over the channel. It was not clear if vessels would have to pay tolls.

A data firm, Kpler, said movement through the strait remained confined to corridors requiring

IRAN, Page A4

College commencement becomes a celebrity series

Schools choosing speakers with star appeal

By Brooke Hauser
GLOBE STAFF

When Northeastern University announced on Instagram that pop star Hilary Duff would be its commencement speaker, the news was met with instant chatter: “epic,” “amazing,” and “childhood dream come true” were among the comments on the video post featuring the school’s mascot, Paws, in a sequined jacket bopping along to Duff’s song “What Dreams Are Made Of.”

Meanwhile, the barbs started slinging on Reddit. “And to think when I graduated from northeastern I only got Christiane Amanpour,” one commenter quipped, referring to CNN’s chief international anchor. Others complained that choosing the 38-year-old mom of four amounted to millennial cosplay — “So Yesterday.”

One thing’s certain: Duff’s got people talking. And while she’s an unorthodox choice in some ways, this commencement season, she’s also one of several celebrity speakers, including Conan O’Brien at Harvard and Henry Winkler at Emerson, coming soon to a campus near you.

As always, the speaker’s challenge is to deliver an inspiring graduation speech. However, the usual “follow your passion” platitudes won’t cut it in 2026, when the

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GETTY IMAGES; ASSOCIATED PRESS; INVISION/AP

Hilary Duff at Northeastern, coach Dawn Staley at Smith, and Conan O’Brien at Harvard are among those who will be speaking to grads.

Lyons says leaving ICE is about ‘family first’

S. Boston native cites son’s last year of high school as he leaves administration

By Emma Platoff
GLOBE STAFF

Todd Lyons, the South Boston native who led ICE during its most controversial stretch, told the Globe he is leaving the agency “on my own terms” to fulfill a promise to return home before his younger son finishes high school.

Lyons, whose family remained in Massachusetts while he worked in Washington, D.C., said he had always intended to return home before the end of President Trump’s second term, and didn’t plan to stay as long as he did. He will step down at the end of May.

His son will be a high school senior next year, and Lyons said he promised not to miss any football or baseball games.

“It’s time to get back home,” he said. “I’ve really always put family first.”

Lyons, 52, has worked for ICE since 2007 and led it since March 2025, making him one of the most senior officials tasked with carrying out President Trump’s mass deportation campaign, a singularly controversial policy at the center of the administration’s agenda.

That role brought intense scrutiny, even hostility; earlier this year, a congresswoman asked Lyons if he thought he was going to hell. Lyons told the Globe he was proud to have been a voice for the tens of thousands of people working under him at the agency.

“I would much rather me be the villain and be demonized than the work the men and women of ICE did and do every day,” Lyons said. “It was really important that they had someone out front to kind of take those blows for them, but also speak on their behalf.”

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LIBBY O’NEILL/ACLU

Rümeysa Öztürk celebrated after earning her doctorate from Tufts.

Tufts grad held by ICE goes back to Turkey

Öztürk’s decision ends legal fight over detention

By Giulia McDonnell Nieto del Rio
GLOBE STAFF

Tufts University graduate Rümeysa Öztürk, who was arrested by masked immigration agents in Somerville last March and held in a Louisiana detention center for six weeks, has returned to her home country of Turkey.

Her case gained international attention after the Trump administration silently revoked her visa and sent ICE agents to arrest her. She had violated no law, but about a year earlier, the former Fulbright scholar had coauthored an op-ed in the Tufts University student newspaper urging the school to listen to undergraduate students who had passed a set of pro-Palestinian resolutions. It became the basis of the government’s effort to deport her.

Öztürk’s decision to leave the US ends her legal battle with the Trump administration. Her cases in federal court, in which she and her attorneys argued that her arrest and detention were unlawful, have been settled, the ACLU said on Friday. The government and Öztürk’s legal team have also jointly moved to dismiss her immigration proceedings.

“I am choosing to return home as planned to continue my career as a woman scholar without losing more time to the state-imposed violence and hostility I have experienced in the United States — all for nothing more than co-signing an op-ed advocating for Palestinian rights,” Öztürk said in a statement released Friday. “I invite every-

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Bloom town

Saturday: Cloudy. High: 49-54. Low: 42-47.

Sunday: Showers. High: 52-57. Low: 37-42.

High tide: 12:01 a.m. 12:35 p.m.

Sunrise: 5:59 Sunset: 7:29

Comics and Weather, **D4-5.** Obituaries, **C9.**

The Supreme Court sided with oil giant Chevron, ruling that it can fight an environmental damage lawsuit in federal court. **A2.**

An 85-year-old Frenchwoman who spent 16 days in US immigration detention went

home to France, the French foreign minister said as he cited “acts of violence.” **A3.**

Massachusetts employers shed 7,200 jobs in February, and the jobless rate ticked up to 4.8 percent, the highest since the summer of ‘21. **D1.**